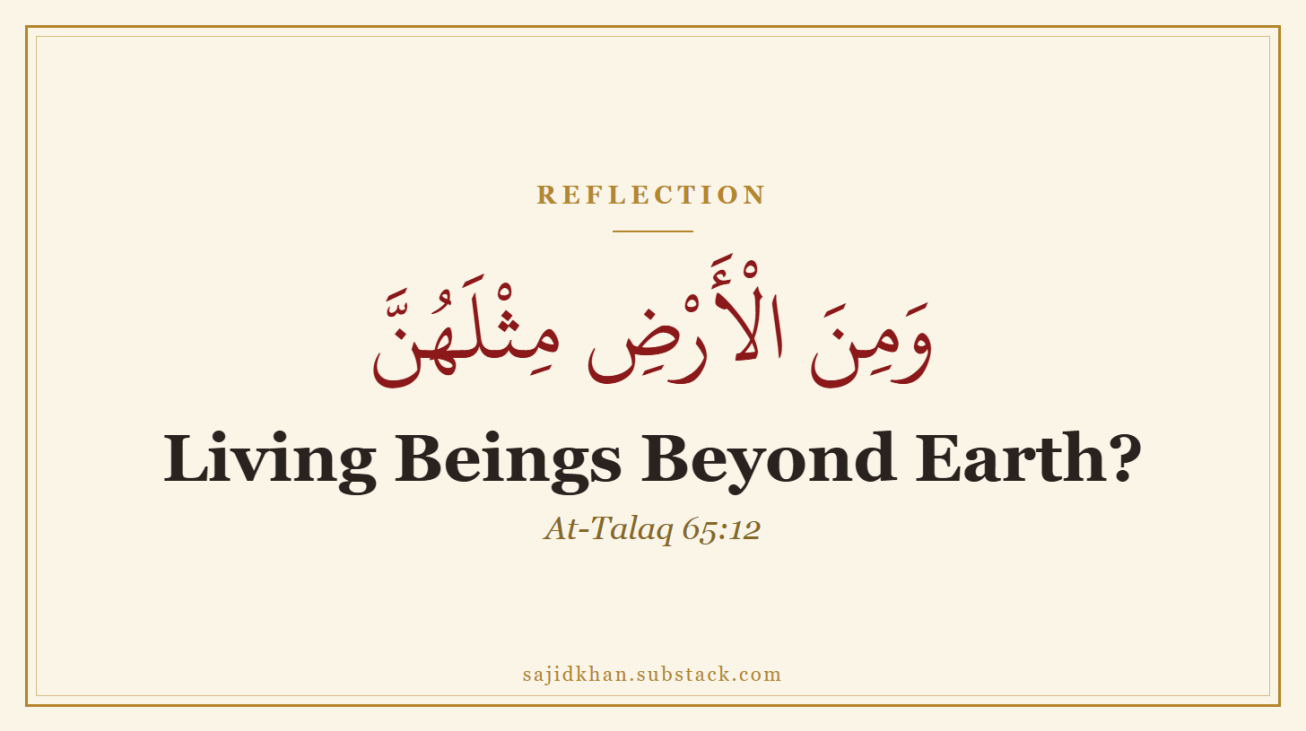



REFLECTION

# Living Beings Beyond Earth?

*Surah At-Talaq 65:12 in Tafheem ul-Qur'an*

In Surah At-Talaq (65:12):

اللَّهُ الَّذِى خَلَقَ سَبْعَ سَمَاوَاتٍ وَمِنَ الْأَرْضِ مِثْلَهُنَّ يَتَنَزَّلُ الْأَمْرُ بَيْنَهُنَّ لِتَعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ عَلَىٰ كُلِّ شَىْءٍ قَدِيرٌ وَأَنَّ اللَّهَ قَدْ أَحَاطَ بِكُلِّ شَىْءٍ عِلْمًا ﴿١٢﴾

*"It is Allah who created seven heavens, and of the earth the like of them. His command comes down among them, so that you may know that Allah has power over everything, and that Allah encompasses everything in knowledge."*

## Maududi's reading

In *Tafheem ul-Qur'an*, Syed Abul A'la Maududi explains "of the earth the like of them" this way: not that there are exactly as many earths as heavens, but that Allah has made other earths in the universe too, which, like ours, are homes for the creatures living on them. In his view, the stars and planets we see are not all empty; many may be inhabited.

He points to Surah Ash-Shura (42:29):

وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ خَلْقُ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَمَا بَثَّ فِيهِمَا مِن دَابَّةٍ

*"Among His signs is the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the living creatures He has spread through both of them."* The word دَابَّة (*daabbah*) means a creature that moves on its own, and the ayah says *both*: the heavens and the earth.

Maududi also notes that among the earliest commentators, Ibn 'Abbas held a similar view, long before anyone imagined other inhabited worlds.

Scholars have read this ayah in more than one way, and Allah knows best. But it is a reminder of how vast His creation is, and how little of it we know.

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